believes in me after watching a video." For Medusa, the rise of creators like her boils down to what she describes as a void in the current political discourse in media. "It is so one-sided," she says. "People have started seeking the other angle. I am part of a system that is trying to show an alternative narrative."

PARTIES WITH A PURPOSE

The perceived lack of attention from the national media outlets in Hindi and English during Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra in 2022-23 is why the Congress began reaching out to social media influencers, with 41-year-old Srivatsa Y.B., a former MNC executive who heads Gandhi's team, chalking out the plan. Party sources say it put certain conditions—like approving the final video and releasing on its social media handles an hour before the influencer releases it. During the Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra, the second leg of Rahul's campaign, the party began engaging with regional influencers in the areas the Yatra crossed. But the experience of engaging with influencers has been bittersweet for the party. "Influencers who are not ideologically aligned with the party are unlikely to remain consistent with their content," says Vaibhav Walia, chairman, communications, War-Room 2024. "Paid by another side, they may post something that is exactly the opposite of what the Congress party believes in, or may even troll us. Some even delete the content once they get payment." There is another hiccup the party is facing. When it tried to reach out to some of the politically active top influencers, they declined to come on board. "The money offered by the BJP was several times higher than what we could afford," says Walia.

TILL 2019, FACEBOOK WOULD GET THE MOST OF THE BJP'S AD BUDGET; IN 2024, IT'S INSTA REELS AND YOUTUBE SHORTS

Instead, the party has now decided to go with ideologically aligned influencers. "Look at Dhruv Rathee. He has been voluntarily posting videos on most of Rahul Gandhi's messages. Ravish Kumar [erstwhile TV journalist] is promoting our causes. These are organic developments and not part of any commercial deal," says Walia. After a year of courting influencers, Rahul's close aides now say that the idea of engaging with them has lost novelty given every other politician is being seen chatting on YouTube. The Congress, in fact, claims that the Gandhi scion doesn't necessarily need amplification through influencers because his own social media landscape has grown exponentially in the past couple of years. "In the past one month, Rahul Gandhi's YouTube channel garnered 457 million views just on YouTube," says Srivatsa. "This is around double of what Prime Minister Narendra Modi got and nearly triple of personalities like Dhruv Rathee and Ravish Kumar. Although



SAMDISH BHATIA

YouTube Channel
UNFILTERED BY SAMDISH

Based in NEW DELHI

SUBSCRIBERS
1.57 million

Not One to Be

A former anchor at ScoopWhoop's *Unscripted*, Samdish began his YouTube channel two years ago with an interview with leader Kanhaiya Kumar. The full video interview received over four million views and saw his digi-

